



सत्यमेव जयते

NITI Aayog



SECTOR AT A GLANCE 03

School Education in India

Education in India

DRAFT

SECTOR AT A GLANCE 03

SCHOOL EDUCATION IN INDIA

EDUCATION IN INDIA

The '**Sector-at-a-Glance**' provides an easy-to-read overview and basic understanding of a sector, sub-sector, or thematic area. The facts and insights on the sector are supported by relevant data and best practices from credible government and multilateral sources. The document covers the structure, key trends, opportunities and challenges, government initiatives, and the way forward for the sector.

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Overview

India's school education system is one of the largest in the world. School education in India comprises the following categories: primary level (classes 1-5), upper primary level (classes 6-8), elementary level (classes 1-8), secondary level (classes 9-10), and higher secondary level (classes 11-12).¹

School education in India has made positive strides in the past two decades, achieving 100% access to school education at elementary levels and gender parity. Two notable endeavours undertaken by the Indian government, namely the Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan (SSA) introduced in 2001 and the Right of Children to Free and Compulsory Education (RTE) Act enacted in 2009, have played pivotal roles in promoting access, inclusivity, and quality school education. As a result of these efforts, the Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) at elementary levels has reached 100 as of 2021-22, where girls' GER is 101.1 and boys' GER is 99.3.² However, the school education system faces challenges such as prevalence of rote learning-based pedagogies, large teacher vacancies, disparities in enrolment progression and high number of sub scale schools.

Given these challenges and opportunities, key government priorities include ensuring universal access to school education at all levels, making learning more holistic and engaging, developing a robust workforce of trained teachers, and promoting effective governance. Numerous central government initiatives, such as the National Education Policy, are currently underway to implement education reforms aimed at ensuring quality education for all.

Going forward, central and state government decision-makers can focus on advancing competency-based monitoring systems at both the central and state level to ensure learning outcome achievement, enhancing governance and resourcing through stronger enforcement mechanisms and collaboration across school types, strengthening teachers' access to effective professional development, and advancing digital and blended models as part of tailored strategies to ensure all socio-economic and disadvantaged groups have access to quality education.

Figure 1: Key school education statistics

Number of schools by level of education

7,60,460 Primary school	1,50,452 Secondary school	14,89,115 Total
4,35,805 Upper primary school	1,42,398 Higher secondary school	

Enrolment by gender across levels of education

	Primary	Upper primary	Elementary	Secondary	Higher secondary
Gross Enrolment Ratio	103.4	94.7	100.1	79.6	57.6
Gender Parity Index	1.03	1	1.02	1	1.02

¹ Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; Note: Pre-primary education is covered in the ECCE sub-sector

² Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

Teacher availability

	Primary	Upper primary	Secondary	Higher secondary
Number of teachers	24,33,800	27,51,815	16,20,001	27,01,507
Pupil Teacher Ratio	26	19	18	27

Expenditure on education

2.8%
of GDP went towards
education between 2015 - 2019

2.9%
of GDP went towards education
between 2019 - 2023

Source: Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; Ministry of Finance, Economic Survey 2022-23

Key trends

This section dives deeper into India's school education landscape, outlining statistics and trends on:

1. Curriculum and pedagogy
2. Teacher recruitment, training, and development
3. School incentives
4. Vocational education within the school education system
5. Parent and community engagement
6. Equity and inclusion
7. Resourcing, governance, and assessment of school education
8. Education for all
9. Financing of school education

Curriculum and pedagogy

The National Education Policy (NEP 2020) proposes reforms in curriculum and pedagogy to ensure that they align with students' developmental needs and interests at various stages of their growth.

The NEP's new curricular and pedagogical structure and the accompanying NCF seek to advance quality foundational stage learning:

The National Education Policy (NEP) of India mandates a significant restructuring of the school education curriculum and pedagogy³. This shift moves away from rote learning and emphasizes a deeper understanding of subjects. A new 5+3+3+4 curricular design caters to different age groups (3-8, 8-11, 11-14, 14-18) ensuring a more responsive and relevant educational experience that helps students develop holistically and gain 21st century skills such as critical thinking through flexible, interactive, experiential learning. The National Curriculum Framework for School Education was published in 2023 to support the implementation of the NEP⁴. It is a comprehensive guide for practitioners, outlining learning standards that are guided by rational thought and autonomy, health and wellbeing and democratic, economic, and cultural participation to achieve desirable values, dispositions, capacities, and knowledge.

Learning outcomes as per the latest National Achievement Survey decline from class 3 to 10:

National Achievement Survey data shows that the average scaled score for class 3 students on a scale of 500 was only 323 for language and 306 for Maths, while for class 5 students, it was 309 for language and 284 for Maths. This further declines for class 10 students to 260 for Modern Indian language and 220 for Maths. Many factors contribute to declining learning outcomes as students' progress across grades, including an insufficient focus on competency-based learning and non-alignment of assessment tools with learning outcomes.⁵

³ Ministry of Human Resource Development, National Education Policy 2020, 2020

⁴ National Steering Committee for National Curriculum Frameworks, National Curriculum Framework for School Education, 2023

⁵ Ministry of Education, National Achievement Survey, 2021; Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

Figure 2: Learning outcomes across grades for classes 3, 5, and 8



Source: Ministry of Education, National Achievement Survey, 2022

Teacher recruitment, training, and development

The quality of teachers significantly influences student outcomes and overall learning experiences. The NEP recognises teachers as the centre of the learning process and emphasises the importance of their recruitment, continuous professional development, working conditions, and employment terms.

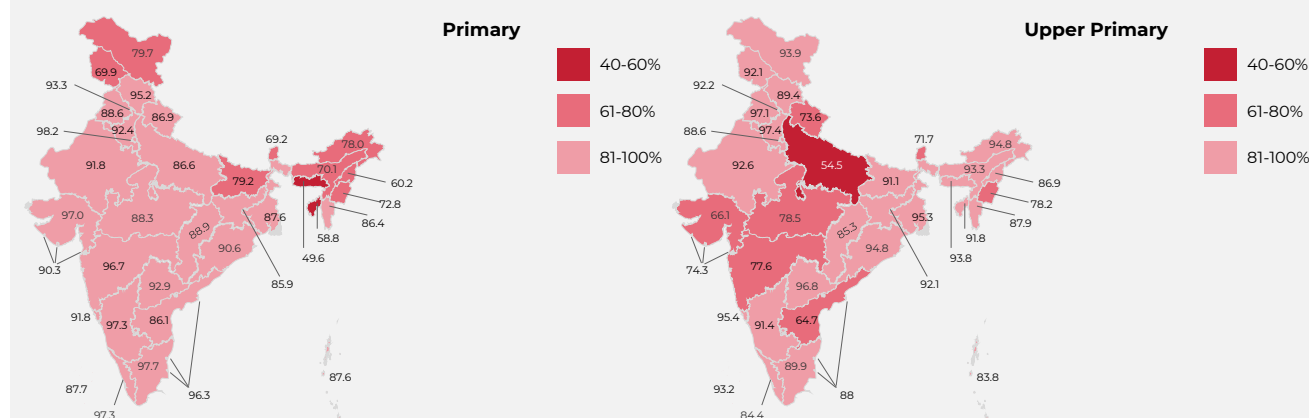
High percentage of trained school teachers:

In India, across different levels of school education, the percentage of trained teachers roughly lies at 90%, with variation across states.⁶

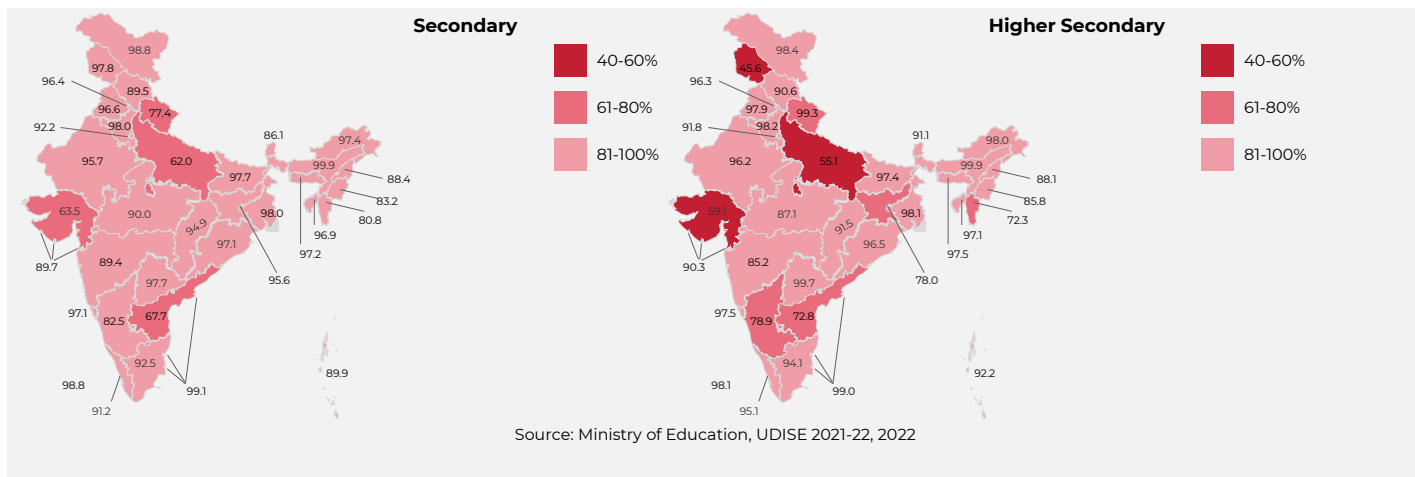
Ongoing training support is provided to teachers/principals through a hybrid medium:

The Ministry of Education, through its National Initiative for School Heads' and Teachers' Holistic Advancement (NISHTHA), provides face-to-face training sessions, interactive workshops, and online modules to provide continuous professional development opportunities to teachers and principals across different locations. Further, it also provides online monitoring and support systems to teachers.⁷

Figure 3: Share of trained primary teachers across all types of management by state and UT (2021-22)



⁶ Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22
⁷ India.gov.in, NISHTHA, accessed July 2021



School incentives

Financial and non-financial incentives offered to school students, particularly those from disadvantaged backgrounds, have improved enrolment rates.

Secondary GER has improved for girls:

As a result of interventions like the National Scheme of Incentive to Girls for Secondary Education, GER at the secondary level for girls has improved from 60.9 in 2010 to 79.4 in 2022.⁸

The PM POSHAN Scheme (previously known as the Mid-Day-Meal Scheme) has helped significantly increase school attendance and nutritional outcomes for primary-age children:

India's school feeding program is the largest of its kind globally and reaches over 100 million pre-primary, primary, and upper-primary-age children in government and government-aided schools.⁹ Multiple evaluations and studies have shown its impact on improving school attendance, enrolment and learning outcomes, particularly for socio-economically disadvantaged groups and girls, as well as supporting intergenerational nutrition outcomes.¹⁰

Provision of state and central-specific incentives to promote enrolment and continuation of school education by SC/ST students:

Under the central government's pre-matric scholarship scheme for SC students, INR 3,500 is provided to SC students in classes 9 and 10 to support students' parents to continue their child's education and reduce dropout rates. Multiple states offer scholarships to SC/ST students pre- and post-matric to enable the transition to higher secondary education.

Vocational education within the school education system

Traditionally considered non-academic, vocational education is being integrated into mainstream education through government initiatives at both central and state levels.

NEP 2020 places strong emphasis on the development of vocational skills from the early stages of schooling:

The NEP proposes an age-appropriate approach to vocational education. In the Foundational (Pre-school and Grades 1-2) and Preparatory Stages (Grades 3-5), various capacities will be developed through play and other activities. These capacities, subsequently termed 'prevocational capacities,' will prove useful in various vocations. During the Middle Stage (Grades 6-8), students will be exposed to a diverse range of

⁸ Ministry of Education, Government of India, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22; Department of School Education and Literacy, Ministry of Education, Government of India, Educational Statistics at a Glance, 2018

⁹ World Food Programme, The State of School Feeding Worldwide 2022, 2023

¹⁰ Suman Chakrabarti, Samuel P. Scott, Harold Alderman, Purnima Menon & Daniel O. Gilligan, Intergenerational nutrition benefits of India's national school feeding program, Nature Communications, 2021; Randeep Kaur, Estimating the impact of school feeding programs: Evidence from mid day meal scheme of India, Economics of Education Review, 2021

work, enabling them to acquire skills relevant to a vocation of their choice in the Secondary Stage (Grades 9-12). This preparation will facilitate their progression into gainful employment.¹¹

Limited number and low reach of secondary and higher secondary schools providing vocational courses:

According to a UNESCO report in 2020, about 10,158 state-government-run schools offer vocational education to over 1.2 million students. However, the number of students benefiting from these programs is still less than 10% of the total number of students in higher secondary schools.¹² In 2022, while the number of secondary and higher secondary schools offering vocational courses increased to 14,435 due to the Samagra Shiksha scheme, this number is still only 5% of the total secondary and higher secondary schools in India.¹³

Parent and community engagement

Parent and community engagement is considered vital for enhancing the overall educational experience of students. Multiple education policy programs and guidelines like the NEP, the NCF-SE, and NIPUN Bharat, in addition to a large body of research, have underscored the critical role of parents and community members in enhancing child well-being, holistic development, and achieving foundational literacy.

Parents and communities are involved in education through mandates and guidelines:

Several formal and informal structures exist to ensure and encourage the involvement of parents and communities in education. School Management Committees (SMCs) and School Management and Development Communities (SMDCs) are formal structures required under the Right To Education Act (2009) in schools and include parents, teachers, local authority representatives and more. Other informal community groups include the Mother-Teacher Association and Women's Associations and Monitoring Groups¹⁴. Recent guidelines and policies such as NIPUN Bharat and NEP 2020 suggest improved parent and community engagement through civil society partnerships, maintaining active communication channels, running workshops, rewarding engagement, encouraging voluntary teaching and more¹⁵.

Parental support is limited:

According to the National Achievement Survey (which involved 38 Lakh students from grades 3, 5, 8 and 10 across 1.23 Lakh government, government-aided and private schools nationally), 25% of schools claim that they lack parental support in students' learning.¹⁶

There is limited capacity building of SMCs:

A National Institute of Educational Planning and Administration report outlined several barriers to parent participation in SMCs, such as illiteracy, a lack of access to school and low internet connectivity. Moreover, among SMC members (75% of whom are parents), only ~20% received training through the manuals prepared by state education authorities¹⁷.

Equity and Inclusion

Equitable and inclusive school education enables equal opportunities and outcomes regardless of socioeconomic background, gender, caste, or disability. Multiple policy interventions like Sarva Shiksha Abhiyan have improved enrolment for disadvantaged groups.

Enhanced enrolment among Socio-Economically Disadvantaged Groups:

Between 2010 and 2022, the Gross Enrolment Ratio (GER) in secondary education for SC and ST students witnessed significant improvement, rising from 70.7 and 53.3 to 84.9 and 78.0, respectively. The enrolment

¹¹ NCERT, National Curriculum Framework for School Education, 2023

¹² UNESCO, Technical and Vocational Education and Training (TVET)- State of the Education Report for India, 2020

¹³ Ministry of Skill Development and Entrepreneurship, Road Map to Enhance Skill Levels, 2022

¹⁴ Sunita Chugh, School Management Committees: A Move Towards Open Government in Education in India, 2021

¹⁵ Ministry of Education, NIPUN Bharat, 2021

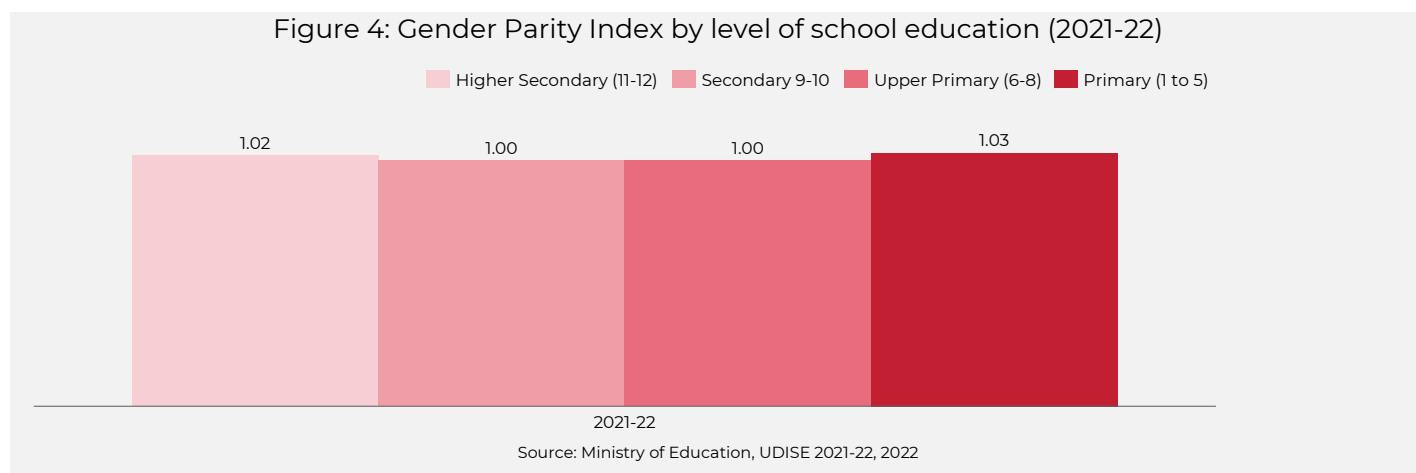
¹⁶ National Achievement Survey, National Achievement Survey (NAS)-2021 Report Card, accessed July 2023

¹⁷ Sunita Chugh, School Management Committees: A Move Towards Open Government in Education in India, 2021

of Children with Special Needs (CWSN) has exhibited positive growth, reaching 22.67 Lakhs in 2021-22, indicating an improvement of approximately 3% compared to 2020-21.¹⁸

Improvement in Gender Parity:

The gender parity index in secondary education has progressed, increasing from 0.88 in 2010 to 1 in 2022.¹⁹



While there has been much progress, key inclusion-related challenges remain to achieve the NEP's vision of equitable and inclusive education:

In 2021-22, despite improvement at an overall scale, the gross enrolment ratio from the primary to the higher secondary levels for SC and ST students witnessed a decline, dropping from 113.7 and 106.7 to 56.1 and 45.2 respectively.²⁰ Further, the proportion of children with special needs enrolled at the primary level was only 0.9% and decreased further to 0.4% at the higher secondary level.²¹

Resourcing, Governance, and Assessment of school education

Central and State Governments have undertaken initiatives, including establishing State School Standards Authority (SSSA), formulating School Development Plans, and increasing budget allocation for adult literacy programs to support clear accountability and build assessment mechanisms across levels.

More than half of all schools in India are government-run:

Based on 2021-22 UDISE data, ~69% of all schools in India were government schools and about 5.5% schools were government-aided schools. On the other hand, ~22.5% of schools fell in the “private- unaided and recognised” category.²²

Most schools in India make School Development Plans, however, only about half conduct regular self-evaluations:

Under the School Quality Assessment and Assurance (SQAA) framework, India carries out school assessments. Approximately 90% of schools in 19 States and UTs created School Development Plans (SDPs) as part of their monitoring and assessment strategy in 2016-17.²³ At least 50% of schools in 17 States and Union Territories (UTs) completed self-evaluations in 2016-17.²⁴

Overall physical infrastructure in schools has improved in the last decade:

The availability of hand-washing facilities in schools across India has significantly increased, with approximately 90% of schools having them in 2021-22, a notable improvement from 43% in 2013-14.

¹⁸ Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2021-22; Ministry of Education, Educational Statistics at a Glance, 2018

¹⁹ Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2021-22; Ministry of Education, Educational Statistics at a Glance, 2018

²⁰ Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2021-22

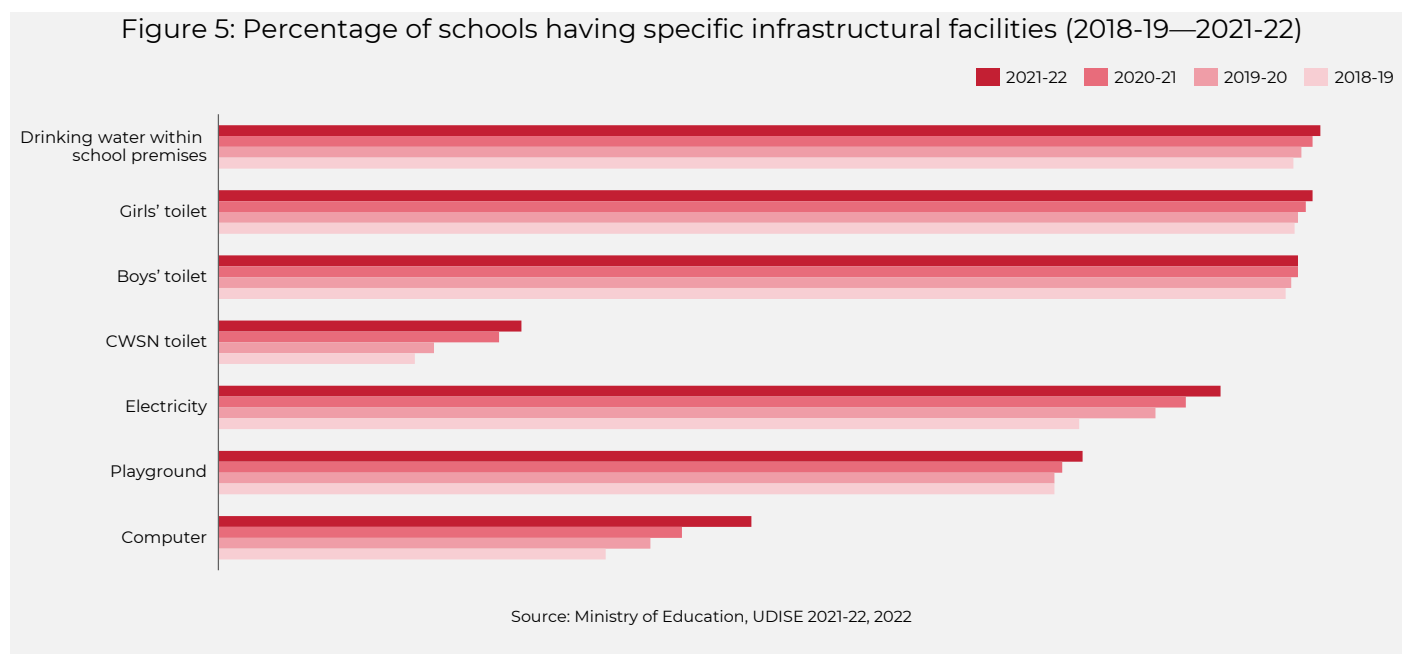
²¹ Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2021-22

²² Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2021-22

²³ Ministry of Education, UDISE+, 2019-20

²⁴ NITI Aayog, School Education Quality Index, 2019

Furthermore, the presence of playgrounds in schools has also improved, with around 77% of schools having playgrounds in 2021-22 compared to 67% in 2013-14.²⁵



Education for all

The New Education Policy (NEP) prescribes a comprehensive adult education curriculum focusing on teacher training.

Increased budget highlights commitment to Adult Education reform:

The New India Literacy Programme (NILP) was launched to encompass all aspects of adult education in alignment with the National Education Policy (NEP) 2020 for the period FYs 2022-2027. Notably, the budgetary expenditure for the programme has witnessed a substantial increase of 57% compared to the 2022 revised estimate.²⁶

76.4 million adults passed literacy tests between 2010 and 2018:

The Sakshaar Bharat Scheme's target was to make 70 million adult non-literates as literates with a focus on Women, SCs, STs, minorities, and other disadvantaged groups. Surpassing this target, approximately 76.4 million learners passed the biannual Basic Literacy Assessment Tests conducted by the National Institute of Open Schooling (NIOS) between 2010 and 2018, resulting in their certification as literate individuals.²⁷

Financing of School Education

India's budgetary expenditure on school education has grown over the years. The NEP endorses a substantial increase in public investment in education by both the Central government and all State Governments to ensure high-quality education for all.

India's budgetary allowance for school education expenditure has grown significantly over the last decade:

The school education budget grew by about 51% from INR 48,781 Crores in 2012-13 to the highest-ever budget of INR 73,498 Crores in 2023-24.²⁸ In 2023-24, this budget comprised 1.3% of the total budgeted

²⁵ Ministry of Education, Government of India, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

²⁶ Ministry of Education, New India Literacy Programme, 2022; British Council, India's National Education Budget for 2023-24, 2023

²⁷ Ministry of Education, Adult Education, 2021

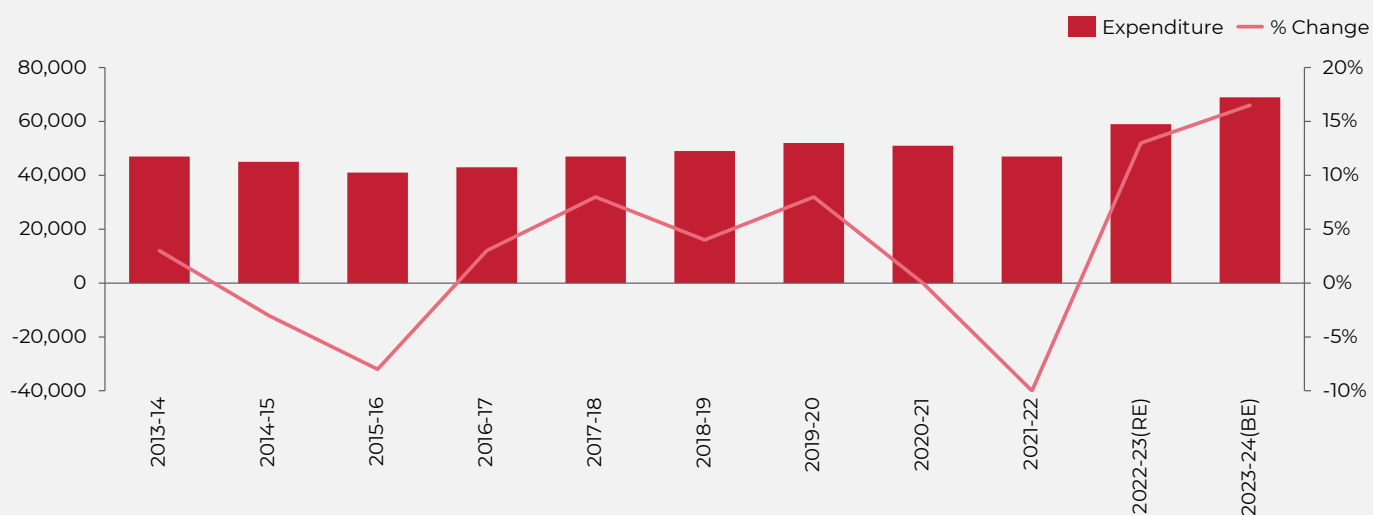
²⁸ Ministry of Education, Shri Dharmendra Pradhan lauds Interim Budget 2024-25 as stepping stone to make India a developed country by 2047, 2024; Ministry of Finance, Expenditure by Ministries/Departments, 2013

government expenditure. The NEP has emphasized that the total expenditure on education reach 6% of GDP at the earliest.²⁹

As of 2022-23, over 50% of India's education budget at the central level was dedicated to school education:

In 2022-23, the Department of School Education and Literacy received 59% of the Ministry's total education budget allocation, while the Department of Higher Education received 41%.³⁰

Figure 6: Trends in expenditure of the Department of School Education and Literacy in INR Crore (2015-16—2023-24)



Source: PRS India, Demand for Grants 2023-24 Analysis: Education, 2023

29 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020
30 PRS, Demand for Grants 2023-24 Analysis, 2023

Opportunities and challenges

Opportunities

This section highlights the outcomes policymakers can achieve by adopting effective school education practices. These revolve primarily around enhanced learning outcomes, more inclusive and equitable learning, strengthened use of e-learning platforms and improved governance, among others.



Enhanced learning outcomes:

Recent policy efforts focus on reducing curriculum content to make space for critical thinking, problem-solving and more holistic, inquiry-based, discovery-based, discussion-based, and analysis-based learning.³¹ Along these lines, the recent National Curriculum Framework for School Education highlights the importance of “competency-based” learning- defining curricular goals, related competencies and attached learning outcomes. It also emphasises on learning as per the varying stage of a student.³²



Enhanced professional growth for teachers:

Teacher quality is inextricably linked to the quality of educational programs and achievement of learning outcomes.³³ Enhancing pre-service and in-service training programs, enabling real-time assessments through robust feedback mechanisms, and creating mentorship and support networks for teachers can foster continuous professional development.



Reduction in disparities:

The NEP emphasizes on bridging the social gaps in access, participation, and learning outcomes for school education.³⁴ Free boarding facilities can be built to support students commuting from remote areas, particularly those from socio-economically disadvantaged groups (SEDGs).³⁵ A single agency and website can coordinate all scholarships available to students from SEDGs to ensure awareness among all eligible students. Tailored approaches like one-on-one teaching, peer tutoring, open schooling, accessible infrastructure, and technological interventions can be effective for children with disabilities.³⁶



Increased access and engagement:

Investing in suitable digital infrastructure, especially learning solutions software can ensure a seamless and effective integration of technology into the education system, enhancing both accessibility and educational outcomes.³⁷ The existing e-learning platforms like SWAYAM and DIKSHA could be expanded to offer teachers a well-organized, user-friendly array of supportive tools designed to monitor learners’ progress comprehensively.³⁸



Improved governance:

Small school sizes make it economically inefficient and operationally complex to ensure quality education, including teacher deployment and provision of essential resources.³⁹ Establishing school complexes, where a secondary school is grouped with nearby lower-grade schools and Anganwadis within a 5 to 10 km radius, can enhance resource efficiency and improve coordination, leadership, governance, and overall management of schools in the cluster.⁴⁰

31 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

32 NCERT, NCF School Education, 2023

33 UNESCO, 2020 vision for India's educational future: teacher quality and the potential of technology, 2020

34 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

35 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

36 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

37 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

38 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

39 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

40 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020



Improved workforce skills:

Robust and innovative government initiatives for adult education can be implemented to accelerate the crucial goal of achieving 100% literacy.⁴¹ These include the creation of a comprehensive adult education curriculum framework, strategic utilization of existing infrastructures such as school complexes and public libraries beyond regular hours, the inclusion of adult education centers within Higher Education Institutions (HEIs) and vocational institutes, as well as active engagement of community members to monitor the progress of non-enrolled students and dropouts.⁴²

Challenges

This section highlights some of the major challenges and constraints facing school education in India. Efforts to resolve such challenges will ensure better learning outcomes, more inclusive and equitable education delivery, and improved school infrastructure to promote more effective learning environments.



Large teacher vacancy and poor quality of teacher education:

There is a shortage of one million teachers across the country, and this challenge is exacerbated by the concentration of teachers in urban locations.⁴³ Over 17% of teaching positions in government schools are vacant nationally.⁴⁴ As the NEP 2020 notes, the majority of standalone teacher education institutes (TEIs) are not seriously committed to imparting quality teacher education and regulatory efforts, thus far, have not effectively enforced quality standards or mitigated malpractices.⁴⁵ Additional research also underscores how the rise of private and self-finance institutes has created quality challenges in the pre-service and in-service training that teachers access, leading to a shortage of professionally-qualified teachers.⁴⁶ The closure of substandard TEIs, creation of professional standards, and improvements to the teacher eligibility test as outlined by the NEP are all steps to correct this challenge.



Inadequate seamless school-to-work transition for secondary-level students:

Students who have completed Grades 11 and 12 with vocational subjects encounter challenges in finding clear pathways to pursue their chosen vocations in higher education. In India, there is a lack of seamless transitions from formal and informal education and training to suitable job opportunities for secondary-level students. This situation creates difficulties for these students in effectively utilising their vocational skills and knowledge in the workforce.⁴⁷



Disparities among SEDGs:

Unequal gender norms often lead to girls being assigned household duties and bearing a greater share of the unpaid care burden at home, resulting in them deprioritising schooling.⁴⁸ As per UDISE 2021-22, about 79,000 schools do not have functional girls' toilets, and about 95,000 schools do not have handwashing facilities.⁴⁹ Schools lacking separate toilets for girls and sanitary products also affect enrolment and attendance levels.⁵⁰ Moreover, 28% of schools in India lack ramps, and only 27% have CWSN toilets.⁵¹ Curricula, pedagogical practices, and teaching and learning materials for CWSNs, given the diversity of learning styles, need greater differentiation and require more flexible school-based assessments.⁵²

41 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

42 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

43 NITI Aayog, Systemic Transformation of School Education - The SATH-E Experience, 2021

44 NITI Aayog, Systemic Transformation of School Education - The SATH-E Experience, 2021

45 Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

46 DMEO, Human Resource Development Sector Report, 2021; UNESCO, No teacher, no class: state of the education report for India, 2021

47 NCERT, Background note- Reimagining Vocational Education

48 Care India, Policy Brief on Girls' Education, 2021

49 Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

50 Care India, Policy Brief on Girls' Education, 2021

51 Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

52 UNESCO, State of the Education Report for India - Children with Disabilities, 2019



High number of sub-scale schools leads to inadequate physical infrastructure and technology access:

Around 28% of public primary schools and 15% of upper primary schools have fewer than 30 students. Economic inefficiencies and operational complexities arise due to small school sizes, leading to difficulties in deploying enough teachers and providing essential resources.⁵³ As a result, 22% of schools operate out of old or worn buildings. Internet connectivity is also limited, with 34% of schools being able to access it.⁵⁴

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⁵³ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

⁵⁴ National Commission for Protection of Child Rights (NCPCR), Safe and Secure School Environment, 2019; UNESCO, No Teacher, No Class: State of the Education Report for India, 2021; Ministry of Education, Report on UDISE+, 2021-22

Institutional framework and policy landscape –

Key ministries and departments

This section highlights the major central government bodies and national-level institutions that oversee school education.



Ministry of Education

The Ministry of Education ensures the implementation of the National Policy on Education in letter and spirit. It functions through two key departments- the Department of School Education & Literacy is relevant for school education here. The Department aims for “universalisation of education” and making better citizens out of young children. At an overall level, the Ministry oversees the development of curriculum frameworks, sets educational standards, promotes inclusive and quality education for all, and works on teacher training and professional development, educational infrastructure, and educational research and innovation.⁵⁵



Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE)

The Board seeks to foster holistic development of learners. CBSE is responsible for designing the curriculum, developing textbooks, and setting examination standards for affiliated schools. It also focuses on continuous improvement in teaching methodologies, assessment practices, and the overall quality of education. It provides guidance and support to schools, organizes teacher training programs, and encourages innovation in education.⁵⁶



National Council of Educational Research and Training (NCERT)

The Council develops national curricula frameworks, textbooks, and instructional materials for various school subjects. NCERT conducts research in education, promotes educational reforms, and provides guidance and support to state education departments. The Council also offers training programs for teachers and contributes to the overall enhancement of the quality of education in the country.⁵⁷



National Council for Teacher Education (NCTE)

The Council ensures planned and coordinated development of teacher education and governs the regulation and proper maintenance of norms and standards for teacher education in India.⁵⁸

Major policies and programs

This section highlights existing policies related to school education and their most prominent features. A more comprehensive list of policies is provided in the policy repository of the NITI Knowledge Platform.



National Education Policy, 2020

The National Education Policy (NEP) proposes a plethora of reforms across all levels of school education. These reforms aim to ensure the quality of schools and transform the curriculum including pedagogy through a 5+3+3+4 design, catering to children in the age group of 3-18 years. Additionally, the NEP calls for a reform of the current exams and assessment system, strengthen teacher training, and restructure the education regulatory framework. It also seeks to increase public investment in education, strengthen the use of technology and increase focus on vocational and adult education.⁵⁹

⁵⁵ Ministry of Education, About, accessed December 2023

⁵⁶ Department of School Education and Literacy, Central Board of Secondary Education (CBSE), accessed December 2023

⁵⁷ Department of School Education and Literacy, NCERT, accessed December 2023

⁵⁸ Department of School Education and Literacy, NCTE, accessed December 2023

⁵⁹ Ministry of Education, National Education Policy, 2020

A noteworthy framework created for the implementation of the NEP is the **National Curriculum Framework for School Education**. It seeks to positively transform the school education system of India as envisioned in NEP 2020. This will provide guiding principles, structures, and elements for the development of curricular content and pedagogy, and will also influence the school environment and culture, thus reforming overall learning experiences for students.⁶⁰



National Credit Framework⁶¹

In line with the NEP 2020's vision to make education more holistic and integrated, the National Credit Framework integrates credits earned by students across school, higher, vocational, and skill education by unifying and enabling mobility across the National Higher Education Qualification Framework, the National School Education Qualification Framework, and the National Skills Qualification Framework. Students earning academic or other credits through any of these frameworks can transfer and accumulate the same across institutions by digitally storing and accessing them through the Academic Bank of Credit.



Samagra Shiksha⁶²

The Scheme aims to ensure that all children have access to quality education with an equitable and inclusive classroom environment. This goal is achieved by incorporating child tracking mechanisms for students in government and government-aided school, enhancing the capacity of Teacher Education Institutions such as the State Council of Educational Research and Training (SCERTs) and District Institute of Education & Training (DIETs), and promoting the integration of digital technology in education.



Right to Education (RTE)⁶³

The act provides for government-sponsored free and compulsory education to all children between 6-14 years of age.

⁶⁰ NCERT, National Curriculum Framework for School Education, 2023

⁶¹ UGC, National Credit Framework, 2023

⁶² Ministry of Education, Samagra Shiksha Abhiyan, 2018-19

⁶³ Ministry of Education, Right to Education (RTE) Act, 2009

Way forward

As outlined by the NEP, the development of holistic and well-rounded learners equipped with the latest 21st-century soft and hard skills requires that India's school education system be multidisciplinary and open to flexible learning pathways, accessible and equitable, well-governed, and well-resourced.

The policies, programs, and frameworks set into motion by the NEP are focused squarely on achieving these objectives: the launch of a new National Curriculum Framework for School Education, the establishment of Performance Assessment, Review, and Analysis of Knowledge for Holistic Development (PARAKH) for setting student assessment guidelines, new National Professional Standards for Teachers, and the continued development of digital learning initiatives through the National Digital Educational Architecture (NDEAR) and the DIKSHA and SWAYAM platforms. Challenges of effective governance, realizing the vision of quality learning outcomes, the access and retention of all SEDGs, and capacity-development of teachers and administrators require continued attention.

Some ideas to enable and sustain policy progress across these fronts, based on proposals from government and industry bodies include:

 Monitor and advance student learning outcomes	Foster comprehensive development of learners • Accelerate the achievement of universal foundational literacy and numeracy (FLN) through measures outlined in NIPUN Bharat • Build knowledge and awareness of parents and care-givers to support foundational literacy and numeracy goals through behavioural science interventions and information, education, and communication campaigns • Grant students with increased flexibility and a broader array of subjects choices, and particularly for academic and career-focused vocational education pathways in secondary school	Shift towards competency-based assessments and tailored remedial mechanisms • Ensure assessments measure achievement of competencies and learning outcomes and are supported by timely, credible, and constructive feedback to students • Integrate remedial programs in the formal schooling system to bridge learning gaps that persist from pandemic-induced learning loss
 Upgrade governance and administrative systems	Optimise school resourcing, monitoring, and consolidation⁶⁴ • Facilitate the establishment of school complexes, each comprising a secondary school along with all associated lower-grade schools, by establishing the necessary state-specific administrative, administrative, and financial guidelines	Build an individualised tracking system⁶⁶ • Enable the electronic tracking (with parental consent) of student learning outcomes throughout their educational career based on assessments and evaluations by using a unique student ID

⁶⁴ Rashmi Diwan, Subitha G. V., Mona Sedwal, and Kashyapi Awasthi, School Complexes in India, NIEPA Occasional Paper 59, 2022
⁶⁶ NITI Aayog, Strategy for New India @ 75, 2019

	- Promote the sharing of teachers and resources across these complexes for improved efficiency - Enhance mechanisms to ensure that new teacher qualification and quality standards are enforced effectively through centralised monitoring systems like Vidya Samiksha Kendras that integrate multiple datasets to oversee performance across multiple student and school outcomes⁶⁵ - In line with the NEP 2020, enable school twinning programs (when public and private schools are paired to learn from each other) to drive effective performance	
 Improve education financing	Deploying innovative funding mechanisms - Enable collaborations between government and private entities to bring additional resources and expertise to the education sector - Encourage investment into social impact bonds, which mobilise private funding to advance social outcomes, with returns linked to the achievement of predetermined goals - Establish dedicated funds to support specific education initiatives	Improving efficiency of existing spending - Shift from input-based to results-based financing to ensure that investments are effectively used to improve education outcomes - Implement policies that provide cash transfers to vulnerable households, helping them overcome financial barriers to education
 Strengthen teacher capacity	Strengthen recruitment processes⁶⁷ - Strengthen Teacher Eligibility Tests (TETs) to inculcate better test material, both in terms of content and pedagogy - Make classroom demonstrations or interviews an integral part of teacher hiring at schools - Ensure that resources for teacher training, in line with the NEP, are increased so that training programs are adequately resourced	Contextualise in-service teacher training and promote continuous professional development (CPD) - Conduct thorough needs assessments to identify specific challenges and requirements of teachers across districts in each state - Leverage DIKSHA to design blended learning programs providing personalized learning to teachers based on their unique needs - Provide CPD opportunities through different modes such as early tenure coaching, peer-learning, resource centres, demonstration classes, sabbaticals for research/advanced

⁶⁵ PIB, Vidya Samiksha Kendra, 2022

⁶⁷ FICCI Arise and EY Parthenon, K-12 Education in India: Vision 2047, 2022

		studies, seminars, visits to other institutions • Develop well-functioning teacher-learning centres at every teacher education institute, by expanding the availability and quality of learning resources (including in Indian languages), establishing shorter-term and blended professional development resources, and setting up a highly-engaged community and network of educators and trainees to spur peer-learning on pedagogical approaches.
 Promote the adoption of digital learning solutions	Enhance digital infrastructure • Advance open-source digital solutions for students, teachers, parents and community members, and administrators that build on existing public digital infrastructure in the education sector like DIKSHA, SWAYAM, and NDEAR through strategic partnerships with education technology actors and service providers • Ensure that classrooms have access to critical digital infrastructure such as high-speed broadband, digital learning labs, and age-appropriate computing and assistive technology devices	Promote a high-quality digital learning ecosystem • Encourage the use of generative AI and machine learning-enabled platforms, and personalised adaptive learning software solutions to create localised and relevant content that is specific to students' immediate pedagogical needs • Support the development of state-specific education technology master plans or roadmaps to align learning goals with at-home and blended learning technologies through planning support, standardised procurement guidelines, and effective monitoring frameworks in line with the NEP and the ICT@Schools scheme
 Boost the quality and reach of vocational education	Enhance quality of vocational education: • Incorporate vocational skills training into the mainstream curriculum at an early stage. This could be done by introducing practical, hands-on modules that align with industry needs, thereby providing students with a glimpse of real-world applications of their academic knowledge. • Implement comprehensive career counselling sessions that highlight the importance and relevance of vocational skills in today's job market.	Increase number and coverage of schools providing vocational education: • Enhance allocation for school-focused vocational education and training to support the development of enabling infrastructure, procure necessary equipment, and train vocational education teachers. Increased funding could also provide scholarships or financial aid to students particularly those from socio-economically disadvantaged groups) who wish to pursue

	These sessions could help students understand the various career paths available to them and make informed decisions about their future.	vocational courses, thereby making it a more attractive option • Encourage the establishment of PPPs where private entities can contribute to both the funding and design of vocational programs in schools. This could not only alleviate the financial burden on the government but also ensure that the vocational training provided is aligned with industry needs, given the private sector's interest in creating a skilled workforce.
 Ensure equity and Inclusion	Increase enrolment, retention, and transition rates for girls • Implement a monitoring and evaluation framework to identify at-risk girls and develop relevant remedial measures aimed at increasing retention⁶⁸ • Deliver gender-specific life skills training and career counselling to enhance girls' agency, promote retention across levels, and facilitate transitions to higher education and employment	Provide inclusive quality education for CWSNs • Customize educational content to accommodate the diverse learning needs of children with varying disabilities, and provide training for teachers in special needs education • Invest in infrastructure such as therapy rooms and accessibility aids to create physical environments conducive to CWSN learning

Recommended readings

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